



For Staff

Sextortion

Responding when a student is being blackmailed with intimate images, often by organised offenders overseas, and the demands for money keep rising

Content Warning

This guide covers sextortion, the blackmail of young people with intimate images, and the risk of suicide.

This is reference guidance, not a training course. Use it to check how to respond, or to prepare for a conversation. It does not replace the school's safeguarding training, policy or the DSL's advice on a specific case.

It contains descriptions of online sexual exploitation and blackmail of children, and references to suicide and self-harm (without any detail of methods). Some of it may be difficult to read, particularly if it connects with your own experience or that of someone close to you.

- You can read it in sections, take a break, or step away at any point.
- If this raises something personal, you can speak in confidence to your line manager, a senior colleague you trust, or the school's Employee Assistance Programme, if it has one, or **Education Support** (free, confidential, 24/7 on 08000 562 561). **Samaritans** is free and open any time, day or night, on 116 123.
- If you have a question about how this guidance applies to a situation you are dealing with, speak to your school's Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL).

If reading this makes you worried about a child now, do not wait until you have finished reading: speak to the DSL or a deputy straight away. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response. **Go to the Quick Reference Card.**

Why This Matters

Sextortion is blackmail: someone threatens to share a nude or sexual image of a young person unless they pay money or send more. In 2025, the Internet Watch Foundation received **394 reports made through Report Remove in 2025** by UK children facing sextortion, an average of nine a week, and **98% of those reports came from boys**, especially those aged 14 to 17 ([IWF, April 2026](#)). The National Crime Agency has alerted hundreds of thousands of education professionals: most UK victims are boys aged 14 to 18, and the offenders are often organised crime groups based overseas, predominantly in some West African countries and also in South East Asia ([NCA, 2024](#)).

It is also a risk to life. The NCA says that some adults and young people have taken their own lives as a result of sextortion ([NCA](#)). [KCSIE 2026](#) names adults posing as children or young adults to exploit them "for sexual, criminal, financial or other purposes" as a contact risk (paragraph 165), lists sexual exploitation, coercion and threats as forms of online sexual harassment (paragraph 540), and points schools to the NCA CEOP guidance on financially motivated sexual extortion (Annex A). The [UKCIS advice](#) says sextortion should be reported to the police. A student who tells you needs a calm, immediate response today.

Scenario Overview

A Year 10 student tells you that someone online, who he believed was a girl his age, offered him money for intimate photos. He sent some. Now the account is threatening to send them to his friends and family unless he pays, and each time he pays, the demand goes up.

What to Keep in Mind

- **This is child sexual exploitation and blackmail.** The student is a victim of crime, whatever he sent and whether or not he accepted money. Tell the DSL **immediately**.
- **Ask directly about suicide.** Shame, fear and deadlines can make a young person feel there is no way out. Asking does not put the idea in their head (Samaritans).
- **The key messages:** don't pay, don't send anything more, stop contact, don't delete, and let adults report it.
- **Never view, copy, forward or delete the images**, and never message the offender. The DSL decides about devices and evidence, following UKCIS.

- **Deadlines are the offender's pressure, not yours.** Stay calm; your calm is contagious.
- If the person responsible is another student, see **Staff Guide 44** (online blackmail between students) as well.

How RESPOND Works in This Scenario

RESPOND is powered by **ACT: Active Intervention** (inaction is not neutral; "just block them and forget it" is not a response), **Contextual Safeguarding** (offenders use platforms, games and followers lists to reach a young person's whole world) and **Trauma-Informed Practice** (shame and fear drive silence; safety comes first). The steps work as a **helix**: see *The RESPOND Helix* section.

Step	RESPOND tool	In this scenario
● Recognise	4 Ps Context Scan	Sudden distress around the phone; talk of money, a deadline or "a way out"
● Engage	The disclosure script; TED questions	No blame; ask directly about suicide; look at nothing on the phone
● Support	Safety check first; "Your calm is contagious"	Risk to life now; stay with them; the deadline can wait
● Pause	90-second grounding; Three Lenses	Don't pay, reply, view, delete or investigate
● Offer	Model alternatives; if in doubt, N before O	Don't pay, don't send more, stop contact, don't delete, report
● Notify	DSL immediately; 999 for immediate danger	Blackmail and possible risk to life: the DSL now, the police via the DSL
● Document	GOLD standard	Their words; platform, account name, demands and deadlines; never describe images

RESPOND is not a checklist to complete in order. Immediate danger or possible risk to life: act first (999 when needed, stay with the child, summon the DSL or a deputy), then return to the steps.

Need the essentials? The *Quick Reference Card* at the end of this guide covers the immediate response on one page.

The One Chance Rule: a disclosure may be a young person's only attempt to seek help. Make it count.

The RESPOND Helix: How the Steps Move

RESPOND is taught in a line, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. In practice it moves as a helix. The first dimension is the steps themselves: you may loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify. The second is time and severity: each turn sits higher as a concern develops. The third is context: a concern involving several children, places or platforms traces a wider spiral.

Relational and Systemic

For a child, safeguarding is **relational**: it happens through people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: the steps, records and shared decisions that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help.

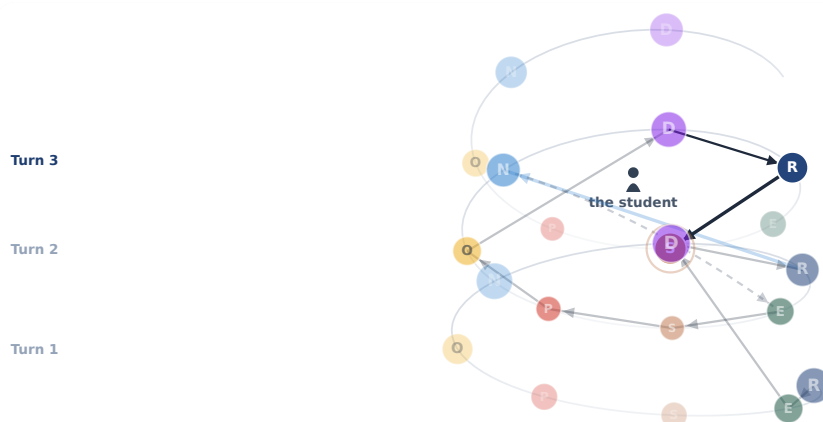
Relational is why children tell. Systemic is why telling works.

The RESPOND steps follow the same shape: Recognise, Engage and Support are relational; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps. Neither works alone. Relationship without the system becomes secrecy, which is why staff never promise to keep a disclosure to themselves. The system without relationship becomes process that children do not trust enough to use. When you share information, be open with the child about what you are sharing and why.

See It Move

One example: a boarder who seems fine in the day, then is in crisis at night. Then see what happens when steps are skipped.

This is a still image of the interactive RESPOND Helix. Open the web version of this guide to step through the examples; every example is also written out in full below.



▼ Read the helix demonstration as text

Sequence

How RESPOND is taught.

1. **The seven steps:** RESPOND is taught in this order, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. Recognise, Engage and Support are the relational steps; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps.
2. **But practice is not a line:** Sextortion moves fast: offenders set deadlines of minutes or hours. A student may seem fine in the day and be in crisis at night. When there is blackmail or any risk to life, you go straight to Notify. Choose an example to see how the steps move.

A boarder at night

A Year 11 boarder is being blackmailed by an account he thought belonged to a girl his age. The helix wraps around him.

1. **Turn 1: seems fine:** At supper a house parent notices he is quiet and checking his phone constantly. He says he is "just tired". Recognise: use the 4 Ps. Patterns: this is new.
2. **Turn 1:** Engage: a light check-in. "You seem a bit flat tonight. Tell me how things are." He says he is fine. Don't push; tell him you're around all evening.
3. **Turn 1:** Document: a short factual note on the safeguarding system, and a word in the handover. One observation can be the first piece of a pattern.
4. **Turn 2: 11pm:** He knocks on the house parent's door, shaking. Someone has his photos, wants money by midnight, and has sent him a list of his followers. He says he "can't see a way out".
5. **Turn 2: straight to Notify:** Straight to Notify: he has spoken of not seeing a way out, so there may be immediate risk. Keep him with you, call the on-call DSL now, and call 999 if you believe his life is at risk or you cannot keep him safe.
6. **Turn 2:** Engage while you wait: stay calm and use the script. "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next." Ask directly and calmly whether he is thinking of ending his life. Don't look at his phone.
7. **Turn 2:** Support: stay with him. "You don't have to pay, and you don't have to answer tonight. This has happened to lots of people, and there is help to deal with it." Your calm is contagious.
8. **Turn 2: hold:** Pause: 90 seconds. Don't message the account, pay, look at images, or tell him to delete everything. The deadline is the offender's pressure, not yours.
9. **Turn 2:** Offer, once the DSL is involved: model the alternative. Don't pay, don't send anything more, stop contact, keep the messages, and let adults report it.
10. **Turn 2:** Document: GOLD, before you go off duty. His words, the time, what you asked about his safety, and what you did.
1. **Turn 3: the next week:** The police are involved and the images have not been shared. He is back in lessons and says he is fine. Loop back to Recognise: the risk of harm can continue after the threats stop.
2. **Turn 3:** Support: planned check-ins with a trusted adult, including about how he is feeling, and a plan for evenings in the house.

When it breaks

The same boarder, when steps are skipped.

1. **Turn 1:** He tells a member of staff he is being blackmailed over photos. Recognise happens.
2. **Support and Pause skipped:** The adult says, "Why would you send those?" and tells him to delete the account and forget it. Support is skipped, and he hears blame.
3. **Notify and Document skipped:** Nothing reaches the DSL. The offender opens a new account and the demands continue. He is alone with it at night.
4. **The helix fragments:** He decides telling made it worse. That is how harm escalates unseen.
5. **Put it back together:** Every step taken puts the structure back. Relational is why children tell; systemic is why telling works.

The Helix is described in the RESPOND Safeguarding Operating System (section 5.2). All examples are fictional.

R

RECOGNISE: Identify the Exploitation and the Risk

Sextortion is designed to be fast, frightening and secret. Recognise two things: that this is exploitation, not a bad choice, and how urgent the risk is.

The 4 Ps Context Scan

People

Often an adult posing as a young person, usually a stranger, sometimes part of an organised group. Sometimes a peer. Who else has been contacted?

Places

Where is the student now, and where will they be tonight: home, the boarding house, alone in a bedroom?

Platforms

Social media, messaging and gaming platforms; a move from one app to another; payment by gift cards, cash transfer or cryptocurrency

Patterns

Contact that turns sexual quickly; threats within minutes or hours; demands that rise after each payment

How It Usually Unfolds

- A friendly or flirtatious contact, often with a fake profile, who moves the conversation on quickly and may offer money or gifts for images
- A nude or sexual image is sent, or an image is edited or generated with AI to look like the young person
- A threat: the offender says they will send it to friends, family, school or followers

- A demand for money, or for more images, with a deadline. Paying rarely ends it; the demands usually grow

Whether the image is real or faked, the fear is the same. Never ask the student to prove which.

Two Immediate Risks

- **Blackmail and exploitation:** a crime in progress. Tell the DSL immediately; the DSL involves the police.
- **Risk to life:** shame, panic and deadlines can lead to suicidal thoughts, sometimes very quickly, including at night. Ask about it directly and stay with the student.
- If you believe the student's life is at risk or they cannot keep themselves safe, call 999.

Signs a Student May Be Being Targeted

- Sudden, intense distress or panic linked to their phone; hiding the screen; flinching at notifications
- Asking to borrow money, selling belongings, or questions about gift cards or money transfers
- Withdrawing from friends, lessons or activities; tiredness from being on the phone at night
- Talk of being trapped, of everything being ruined, of being a burden, or of "a way out"
- A sudden, unexplained calm after a period of panic, which can be a warning sign

No Disclosure Needed

Many young people don't know what sextortion is, or how to report it: in NCA research with teenage boys, 74% did not fully understand what it was and 73% did not know how to report it (NCA, 2025). Shame keeps many silent. If you notice the signs, tell the DSL **without waiting for a disclosure**, and record what you saw and heard. You don't need to wait for it to happen again.

What the Law Says (England and Wales)

The student has been targeted by criminals. Know the frame; leave every decision about offences to the police.

- **Child sexual exploitation:** a form of child sexual abuse, which can include involving children in producing sexual images and grooming online, and may involve an exchange for something the child wants or for the offender's financial advantage, and can be committed by an individual or an organised network (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 38 and 42 to 44).
- **Blackmail:** making an unwarranted demand with menaces, with a view to gain or intent to cause loss (Theft Act 1968, section 21).
- **Threatening to share an intimate image** is an offence; the prosecution does not have to prove the image exists (Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 66B, inserted by the Online Safety Act 2023).

- **Nude images of under-18s:** taking, making, sharing or possessing an indecent image of anyone under 18 is an offence, including computer-generated pseudo-photographs (Protection of Children Act 1978, section 1; Criminal Justice Act 1988, section 160).

KCSIE says staff should explain that "the law exists to protect children and young people, not criminalise them" (paragraph 557). Criminal responsibility in England and Wales starts at 10 (GOV.UK), which matters where the person responsible is another student.

Staff never decide whether an offence has been committed. Describe what you saw and heard, and report it to the DSL. Legal references checked 28 September 2026.

What the Data Shows

394

reports made through Report Remove in 2025 involved sextortion: 34% of confirmed cases, up from 23% in 2024

IWF, 2026

98%

of those 2025 Report Remove sextortion reports came from boys, especially those aged 14 to 17

IWF, 2026

91%

of victims in UK sextortion cases dealt with by the Internet Watch Foundation in 2023 were male

IWF data, cited by the NCA, 2024

117

sextortion reports a month, on average, from under-18s to police forces in the first five months of 2024

NCA, 2025

These are reports, and the IWF describes its figures as the "tip of the iceberg". Girls and younger children are targeted too, and some sextortion involves demands for more images rather than money. Checked 28 September 2026.

E

ENGAGE: No Blame, Direct Questions

Your first words decide whether the student keeps talking. They may expect anger, disgust or punishment. Show them none of it.

What a Student Might Say

"I've done something really stupid. Someone's got pictures of me and they want money by tonight or they'll send them to everyone. I already paid once."

The RESPOND disclosure script:

"I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next."

- **Name it:** "What's happening to you is a crime. The people doing this are criminals, and they do it to lots of young people. You've done the right thing by telling me."
- **TED:** "Tell me what's happened." "Explain what they're asking for, and by when." "Describe how you're feeling right now." Never "why": "why did you send it?" is blame.
- **Ask directly about suicide:** "Sometimes when people are this frightened, they think about ending their life. Are you having thoughts like that?" Stay calm whatever the answer.
- **Look at nothing on the phone.** Don't take it, scroll it or ask to see messages. If an image appears, look away.

Helpful

- "You're not in trouble for telling me."
- "You don't have to pay, and you don't have to answer them."
- "This happens to a lot of people, and there is help to deal with it."

Unhelpful

- "Why would you send something like that?" (blame)
- "Just pay them and it'll go away." (it rarely does)
- "Delete everything and block them." (loses evidence the police may need)
- "Show me what they've got." (never view the images)
- "Your parents will be furious." (adds to the fear that keeps young people silent)

If a Friend Tells You

Thank them: "Telling me was the right thing to do." Use TED to find out where the student is and whether they are safe now. Don't ask the friend to look at messages, collect proof or contact anyone. If the friend is worried the student might hurt themselves, go to the DSL immediately. If

you see an image being passed round, act **if it is safe to do so**, using the 4Ds, with Delegate first: get the DSL, and don't handle the phone to look.



SUPPORT: Safety First

Safety comes before everything else, including the offender's deadline. Stay with the student, and keep your voice steady.

Safety Check

Right Now

- "Are you thinking about hurting yourself, or ending your life?"
- "Have you hurt yourself?"

Today and Tonight

- "What have they said will happen, and when?"
- "Where will you be tonight, and who with?"

If the Student Has Thought About Ending Their Life

- **Stay with them.** Send another adult for the DSL; don't leave the student alone or send them to find someone.
- "Thank you for telling me. You're not on your own with this. We're going to get you help now."
- Don't ask about methods or plans beyond what you need to keep them safe. The DSL leads the risk assessment.
- Call 999 if their life may be at risk or they cannot keep themselves safe.

Immediate Practical Support

- A private, quiet space, with another adult nearby; water; time
- Ask them not to reply, not to pay, not to send anything more, and not to delete anything
- Let them decide whether to keep the phone switched off, put away or with them for now. Don't read it or take it as a punishment; the DSL decides whether a device needs to be secured
- Reassure them that the adults will deal with the offender. They don't have to

SEND, Neurodivergence and Language

- Some students may find it harder to recognise a fake profile or manipulation, and may be targeted because of it. Use clear, concrete language and allow processing time.
- Students with EAL may be targeted in their home language, or fear what telling means for their family. Use a professional interpreter, never another student or a family member.
- Record any adjustments you made.

Support for Others Involved

If the offender has sent the image to other students, those students may have received an indecent image of a child. The DSL follows UKCIS for them (see **Staff Guide 10** (nude and semi-nude images)), and makes sure no one blames or teases the student targeted. Friends who helped the student tell also need thanks and a check-in.

P

PAUSE: Consider Your Approach

Take 90 seconds: breathe, lower your shoulders, check your own state. A countdown, a panicking student and sexual content can make adults rush. Pause is where you stop the rush.

Three Lenses

Lens	In this scenario
Risk	Is there a risk to life now? Has the student already paid? Has anything been shared? Is the deadline tonight? Are there signs of an adult, a peer or an organised group? Is the student a boarder, or going home to an empty house?
Rights	The right to be safe, believed and not blamed; to a say in how parents are told; to privacy, with no one in school viewing the images unless the DSL judges it unavoidable (UKCIS,

Resources The DSL, the police, CEOP, Report Remove and Take It Down, the school's mental health support, Childline, and the safe adults in the student's life

What You Must Not Do

Don't View, Copy or Delete

- **Never view, copy, forward, save or delete the images**, even as evidence (UKCIS; KCSIE 2026, paragraph 558)
- Don't photograph the screen or ask for anything to be sent to you
- Don't tell the student to delete the account or the messages

Don't Investigate or Engage

- Don't message, threaten or negotiate with the offender
- Don't try to trace the account or search for the images online
- Don't advise paying, even "just to buy time"

Don't Promise Secrecy or Outcomes

"I can't keep this between us, because I'm worried about your safety. I'll tell the DSL now, whose job is to help keep you safe, and only people who need to know. I'll tell you what's happening."

- Don't promise the images will never be shared, or that anyone will be caught

Don't Blame or Minimise

- Not "you should have known better" or "you only have yourself to blame"
- Not "it's only a picture" or "everyone's forgotten it by next week"

Check Your Own Response

- Notice any judgement about the student sending images, or about boys asking for help. Neither changes what they need
- You don't need to understand the platform. Believe, protect, report
- Afterwards, look after yourself. Talk to the DSL or your line manager. Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff.



OFFER: Model Alternatives

If in doubt, N before O: with blackmail and a possible risk to life, the DSL is involved before you offer options. Then explain what happens next, and model a different response to the offender's pressure.

Explain What Happens Next

"Here's what happens now. I'm going to get our safeguarding lead, and I'll stay with you. They'll talk with you about how you're feeling and about the police, who deal with this all the time. Please don't pay, reply or delete anything. Your parents or carers will usually need to know, and we'll talk with you about how. None of this is your fault. What questions do you have?"

Be honest about information sharing. Staff should share safeguarding information as early as possible, and data protection law does not prevent it; safeguarding children is a lawful basis for sharing sensitive information without consent where appropriate (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 142 to 148). What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. From 30 September 2026, the Information Sharing Duty (section 16LA, Children Act 2004) also requires the organisations it covers to share where its tests are met; the DSL decides how it applies. So don't ask for consent as if it were the legal basis. Tell the student what will be shared, with whom and why, unless that would increase the risk, and listen to their views: they shape the plan. Agreeing to a service, such as counselling, is a separate question, and their agreement matters there.

Options, Not Orders

- "Would you like me to stay while you talk to the DSL?"
- "How would you like your parents told: with you there, or with us leading?"
- "Would it help to use Report Remove together with the DSL?"

Some things must happen to keep them safe, such as telling the DSL and the police. Where there is a choice, give it to them.

Model the Alternative

What Helps

- **Don't pay.** Paying usually leads to more demands
- **Don't send anything more**
- **Stop contact.** Don't reply or negotiate
- **Don't delete** messages, account names or payment details
- **Report**, with the DSL's help

What the Offender Wants

- Panic, secrecy and speed
- Payment, and then another payment
- The young person believing no adult will help

This advice comes from the NCA (NCA) and the IWF (IWF). Blocking is part of stopping contact; where possible the DSL agrees how evidence is kept first, but if blocking now is what the student needs to feel safe, safety comes first.

Reporting and Removal (the DSL Decides Who Does What)

- **Police:** 101, or 999 if there is a risk to life. The UKCIS advice says sextortion should be reported to the police (UKCIS).
- CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency): ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse, including sextortion. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking.

- Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation): helps under-18s in the UK confidentially report a nude or sexual image or video of themselves so it can be removed or blocked online, at childline.org.uk.
- Take It Down (National Center for Missing & Exploited Children): available worldwide, including the UK, for images taken when someone was under 18. The image stays on the device; a digital fingerprint is shared with participating platforms only, so it cannot stop sharing everywhere (takeitdown.ncmec.org).

Support in School and Beyond

- A named trusted adult and planned check-ins, including in the evenings for boarders
- Counselling or mental health support, arranged by the DSL
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at childline.org.uk (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- Samaritans: 116 123, free, any time, day or night
- NHS 111, option 2, for urgent mental health help, any time, or NHS 111 online (nhs.uk)

N NOTIFY: Report the Concern

Tell the DSL as soon as is practicably possible. Here that means immediately: this is blackmail and possible exploitation, and there may be a risk to life. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Who and When

- Send a colleague or use the school's urgent system: "I need the DSL now. A student is being blackmailed with images." Another adult stays with the student.
- If the DSL or a deputy is not available, go to a senior leader, or take advice from children's social care (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 61). Don't wait.
- Anyone can refer directly to children's social care or the police; telling the DSL does not remove your own responsibility.

What to Tell the DSL

- Who the student is, where they are now, and who is with them
- What they said, in their words, including what they said when you asked about suicide

- The demand, any deadline, whether they have paid and how, and whether anything has been shared
- The platform and account name, as the student told you; whether contact is continuing
- What you have said and done, and that you have not viewed anything

▼ For the DSL: assessment, external agencies and parents

Most staff need only: tell the DSL, today, with the information above.

The DSL's Initial Actions

- Assess the risk to life now and agree the route to support: the school's mental health lead, the GP, children and young people's mental health services, NHS 111, option 2, for urgent mental health help, any time, or NHS 111 online (nhs.uk), or 999
- Follow UKCIS: blackmail and the involvement of an adult are reasons for an immediate referral to the police and, where needed, children's social care. **Staff Guide 10** (nude and semi-nude images) sets out the full procedure
- Report to the police (101, or 999 if there is a risk to life); consider CEOP; agree with the police how devices and evidence are handled, following UKCIS and DfE searching guidance
- Help the student use Report Remove or Take It Down, if they want to
- Where images have reached other students, follow UKCIS for each of them, and agree with the police what is said to other families, and when, before any contact
- Plan today and tonight: supervision, the journey home or the boarding house, and who the student can contact out of hours
- Where the Information Sharing Duty applies (from 30 September 2026), apply its three tests: share information that is relevant to safeguarding or promoting the child's welfare (Relevance) and may help the recipient to safeguard or promote their welfare (May facilitate), unless sharing would be more detrimental to the child than not sharing (Detriment), which applies only in extremely limited circumstances; record the decision to share or not share, with the rationale, and be transparent with the young person unless that would increase the risk. Data protection law still applies to how information is shared
- Record on the safeguarding system, with a chronology, and set review dates

When to Involve Other Agencies

Agency	When
Police (999 or 101)	Every sextortion case; 999 where there is a risk to life or immediate danger
CEOP (National Crime Agency)	Online sexual abuse, including sextortion and grooming

Agency	When
Children's social care	Significant harm or risk of it; exploitation; where home may not be safe or supportive
Mental health services	Suicide or self-harm risk: NHS 111, option 2, for urgent mental health help, any time, or NHS 111 online (nhs.uk); 999 in an emergency
Professionals Online Safety Helpline	Advice for staff on handling the online side

Where a Student Is 18

At 18 a student is legally an adult. The child safeguarding framework in KCSIE applies to under-18s, but the school still has welfare responsibilities. Where an 18-year-old is involved, the DSL considers adult safeguarding, police and welfare pathways alongside the school's procedures, and the adult student's own views and consent in a different way. This matters in sixth form and in boarding, where students turn 18 during their final year.

Before Contacting Parents or Carers

Parents will usually be told the same day, and most can help. Fear of their reaction is one reason young people stay silent. Talk with the student about how their parents will be told, and consider whether telling them could increase the risk; where it could, seek advice from children's social care or the police first. Where home may be part of the problem, the DSL thinks carefully about how, and whether, family is told.

Parent contact: what to say

- "We need to talk to you about [name]. Someone online has been blackmailing them with images. [Name] has done nothing wrong by telling us, and is safe and with us now."
- "The advice is: don't pay, don't reply, don't delete anything. We are reporting it to the police. Please don't be angry with [name]: they need to know you're on their side."

The IWF advice for parents and Parent Guide 10 are good to share.

D

DOCUMENT: Record Observations

Record as soon as is practicably possible, on the school's safeguarding system, using **GOLD**. The police may use your record. Record what you were told; never describe or attach any image.

GOLD**Ground**

Date, time, place, who was present, who you are, and how it came to your attention

Observe

What you saw and heard, with exact words in quotation marks

Language

Neutral, factual and non-diagnostic. No opinions or labels

Do

What you did, what you said would happen next, and why

Example: Exact Words

- Student said: "They said if I don't send £100 by 9 o'clock they'll send the pictures to everyone I follow."
- Student said: "I paid £50 on Saturday. Then they wanted more."
- When asked about suicide, student said: "I thought about it last night. I don't know now."

Recording template

SAFEGUARDING CONCERN: SEXTORTION (ONLINE BLACKMAIL WITH IMAGES)

Date and time:

Student: name, year, tutor group or house

Recorded by: name and role

How it came to your attention:

WHAT THE STUDENT SAID (exact words in quotation marks):

DEMANDS: what was asked for, amounts, deadlines, as the student described

PAYMENTS ALREADY MADE (as described):

PLATFORM(S) AND ACCOUNT NAME(S), as the student told you:

HAS ANYTHING BEEN SHARED? (as described):

SUICIDE AND SELF-HARM: what I asked, and what the student said

IMAGES: I did not view, copy or forward any image (never describe one)

OBSERVATIONS (presentation, emotional state):

WHAT I DID AND SAID (with times):
SHARED WITH: DSL (name, time, how)
THE STUDENT'S WISHES AND VIEWS:
Signed and dated:

What Not to Record

- Any description of an image, or a copy or screenshot of one
- Judgements such as "he was foolish" or "she put herself at risk"
- Your emotional reaction, or guesses about who the offender is

UKCIS: The Nude Image Procedure in Brief

Where a nude or semi-nude image of an under-18 is involved, the DSL follows the UKCIS advice. In brief:

- Staff never view, copy, print, share, store or save the image, and tell the DSL straight away
- The DSL holds an initial review meeting with appropriate staff
- Blackmail, coercion, the involvement of an adult, or a risk of immediate harm (including suicide or self-harm) mean an immediate referral to the police and, where needed, children's social care
- The DSL decides about devices, parents and support, and records every decision

Staff Guide 10 (nude and semi-nude images) sets out the full procedure. Staff do not need to know every step: tell the DSL.

Boarding and Residential Life

For boarders, a deadline set at night arrives in a bedroom, away from family. The house team may be the first to know.

Step	In boarding
● Recognise	Contact and deadlines can come late in the evening or at night, when a boarder is alone. Notice a boarder who is suddenly withdrawn, up late on their phone, or asking to borrow money.
● Engage	Boarders often tell house staff late at night. Use TED and the script; talk somewhere visible, and let another adult know.

Step	In boarding
● Support	Safety tonight comes first: if there is any risk to life, stay with them. The DSL plans supervision and checks overnight with the duty team.
● Pause	Don't search rooms or phones, or message the offender. Don't wait until morning if there is any risk.
● Offer	If in doubt, N before O. Then model alternatives: don't pay, stop contact, don't delete, tell.
● Notify	The on-call DSL immediately where there may be immediate risk, including at night. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999; out of hours, the emergency duty team.
● Document	Record on the safeguarding system before you go off duty, using GOLD. A handover note is not a substitute.

Boarders' Routes to Help

- **Boarders can always contact their house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.** Make sure every boarder knows how.
- An independent person outside the staff whom boarders can contact directly (NMS 11.4), often called the independent listener
- Boarders must be able to contact their families privately; monitoring of communications should be proportionate (NMS 12.1)
- International boarders: agree with the DSL who contacts parents or guardians, when, and in what language, using interpreters where needed

Source: National Minimum Standards for Boarding Schools (2026).

For international boarders, offenders may threaten to contact family abroad. The DSL agrees how and when parents or guardians are told, and in what language.

Identity and Intersecting Harm

- **Boys** make up most reported victims, and may worry about being mocked or judged if they ask for help. Say plainly that boys are targeted and that it is not their fault. Girls are targeted too, sometimes with demands for more images or sexual acts rather than money, and need the same response (NSPCC Learning, 2024).
- **LGBTQ+ students** may also be threatened with being outed. The DSL considers this when planning parent contact.

- **Students with SEND** may be more easily deceived, and may need extra support to understand that they are not in trouble.
- **International students and families** may have different expectations of the police or fear consequences at home. Use interpreters, and explain that the police treat the young person as a victim.

Additional Resources and Support

For Students

- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **For under-18s, this is the place to start.**
- Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation): helps under-18s in the UK confidentially report a nude or sexual image or video of themselves so it can be removed or blocked online, at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk)
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- Samaritans: 116 123, free, any time, day or night
- Internet Watch Foundation, *Sextortion or online blackmail: help for under-18s*

For Parents and Carers

- Internet Watch Foundation, *Advice for parents of children who are being 'sexorted' online*
- NSPCC Helpline: 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- YoungMinds Parents Helpline: 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)
- NHS 111, option 2, for urgent mental health help, any time, or NHS 111 online ([nhs.uk](https://www.nhs.uk))

For Staff

- Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff
- Professionals Online Safety Helpline (UK Safer Internet Centre): helpline@saferinternet.org.uk, for anyone working with children

- NCA CEOP Education, *Financially motivated sexual extortion: alert for education settings* (listed in KCSIE 2026, Annex A)
- CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency): ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse, including sextortion. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking
- NSPCC Learning, *Young people's experiences of online sexual extortion or 'sextortion'* (September 2024)

Statutory Guidance and Law

- Department for Education, *Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026*
- HM Government, *Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026*
- Department for Education, *Information Sharing Duty: statutory guidance* (in force 30 September 2026)
- Department for Education, *RSHE statutory guidance* (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026)
- Department for Education, *National minimum standards for boarding schools* (2026)
- UKCIS, *Sharing nudes and semi-nudes: advice for education settings working with children and young people* (updated February 2024)
- Department for Education, *Searching, screening and confiscation* (guidance for schools)
- Theft Act 1968, section 21 (blackmail)
- Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 66B (sharing or threatening to share an intimate photograph or film; inserted by the Online Safety Act 2023)
- Protection of Children Act 1978, section 1 (indecent photographs of children)
- Criminal Justice Act 1988, section 160 (possession of indecent photograph of child)
- GOV.UK, *Age of criminal responsibility*

Figures and Alerts

- Internet Watch Foundation, *Nine reports a week from UK children facing online sextortion* (7 April 2026)
- National Crime Agency, *NCA issues urgent warning about 'sextortion'* (29 April 2024)
- National Crime Agency, *Online campaign to tackle 'sextortion' among young teenage boys* (20 March 2025)
- National Center for Missing & Exploited Children, *Take It Down: frequently asked questions*
- Samaritans, *Media guidelines for reporting suicide*

Contacts, figures and legal references checked 28 September 2026. Verify at point of use.

Quick Reference Card

Immediate Danger Comes First

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response.

Recognise

- Panic about the phone, requests for money, talk of a deadline or "a way out"
- Sextortion is exploitation and blackmail; the student is a victim
- Boys aged 14 to 18 are most often targeted; anyone can be
- No disclosure needed

Respond

- "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- Ask directly about suicide; stay with them
- Don't pay, don't send more, stop contact, don't delete, report
- Never view, copy, forward or delete images

Notify

- DSL immediately; another adult stays with the student
- Risk to life or immediate danger: 999
- The DSL reports to the police and follows UKCIS

Document

- GOLD: Ground, Observe, Language, Do
- Their words; demands, deadlines, payments, platform
- Never describe an image

Emergency, DSL, Police: Three Different Things

- **Immediate danger or risk to life:** 999 now, stay with the student, then the DSL.
- **Every case:** the DSL, immediately. The DSL leads the response; you don't decide about police.
- **Police referral is not optional** where intimate images are involved and any of these apply: an adult is involved; the young person has been coerced, blackmailed or groomed, or there are concerns about their capacity to consent (for example, SEND); the content is unusual for their developmental stage, or violent; sexual acts and a child under 13; or immediate risk of harm, such as suicidal thoughts or self-harm. The DSL makes an immediate referral to the police and/or children's social care (UKCIS, section 2.3). Sextortion is blackmail, so it always meets this test.

Key Numbers

- Emergency: 999; police non-emergency: 101
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- Samaritans: 116 123, free, any time, day or night
- NHS 111, option 2, for urgent mental health help, any time, or NHS 111 online ([nhs.uk](https://www.nhs.uk))
- Your DSL: named in the school's safeguarding policy

Online Evidence: One Rule

- **Ordinary messages or posts a student has already shown you:** note what is relevant (platform, date, who, exact words) in your record. Don't ask to see more or scroll through a phone, especially where messages may be sexual, because they may contain images. Don't log in to accounts, search profiles or investigate, and never transfer anything to a personal device.
- **Nude or semi-nude images of anyone under 18:** don't intentionally view, copy, screenshot, forward, save or delete them. Tell the DSL straight away. If you see one by accident, tell the DSL, ask for support if you need it, and record that it was seen and what you did, without describing the image (UKCIS).
- The DSL decides what happens to devices and content.

Your School's Contacts

This guide is generic. Schools add their own details here, or keep a completed copy with this card, so that anyone responding, including at night, has the routes to hand.

Contact	Name and how to reach them
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	
Deputy DSL(s)	
Out-of-hours and boarding on-call safeguarding contact	
How to record a concern (system or form)	
Local authority children's services front door	
Out-of-hours emergency duty team	
LADO (concerns about adults)	
Police: 999 (emergency); 101 (non-emergency)	

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Reference Scenarios · Staff Guide 88

Scenario 88: Sextortion

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Aligned with: KCSIE 2026 | Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026 | Information Sharing Duty (September 2026) | UKCIS Sharing nudes and semi-nudes (2024) | NCA CEOP financially motivated sexual extortion alert | Theft Act 1968 | Sexual Offences Act 2003 | RSHE statutory guidance (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026) | NMS for Boarding Schools 2026

Last Updated: September 2026 | Next Review: September 2027, or on publication of KCSIE 2027 if sooner

For staff in schools and other settings working with children. You may share it with colleagues. Share the student and parent guides, not this page, with students and families.